

Habilidades Comunicativas en Lengua Extranjera
Profesional (Inglés)

Unit 2. Business Communication

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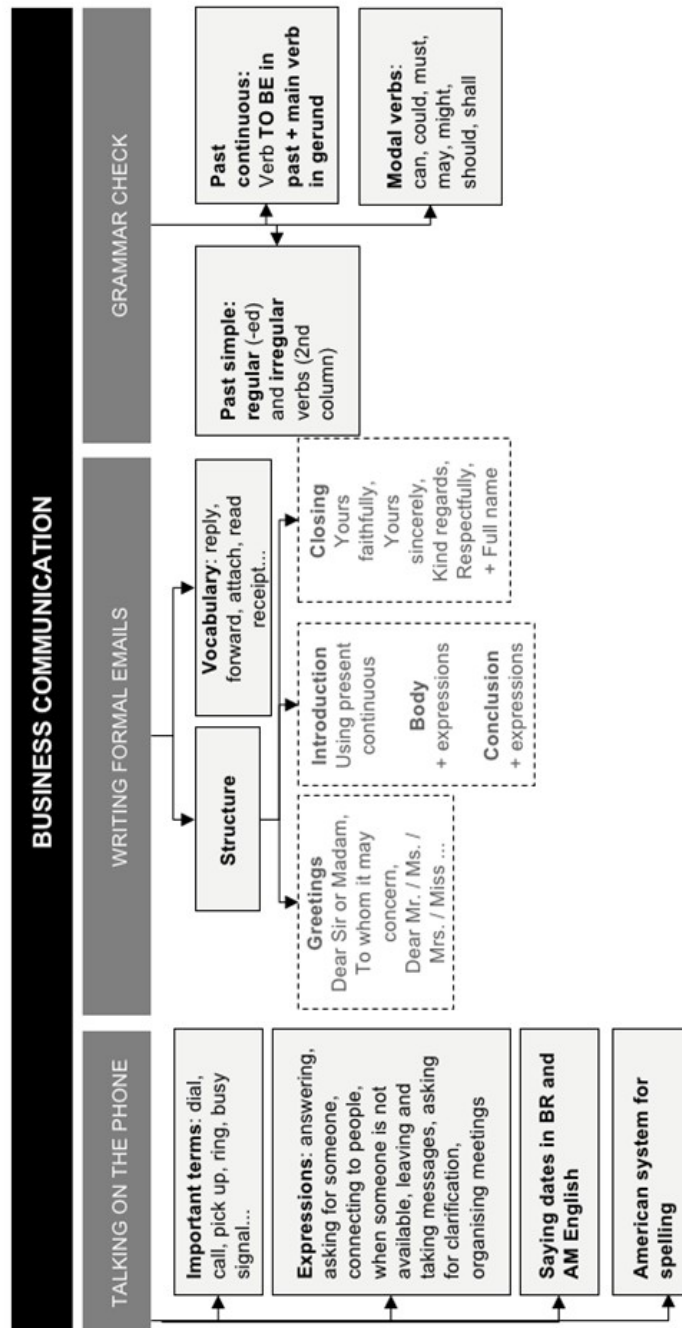
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2.1. Introduction and Objectives

Effective business communication is essential in the professional world. Whether through **phone conversations or written correspondence**, clear and professional communication enhances workplace efficiency and fosters strong professional relationships. This unit focuses on two key aspects of business communication: handling professional phone calls and writing formal emails. Additionally, it includes a **grammar check** on key structures that are frequently used in professional interactions, such as the past simple and past continuous tenses, as well as modal verbs. Mastering these skills will help students communicate more confidently and effectively in a business environment.

By the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- ▶ **Objective 1:** Use appropriate strategies and expressions for professional phone calls.
- ▶ **Objective 2:** Structure and write formal emails with the correct tone and commonly used phrases.
- ▶ **Objective 3:** Apply grammatical structures such as the past simple and past continuous in business contexts.
- ▶ **Objective 4:** Use modal verbs accurately to express necessity, obligation, and probability in professional communication.

This unit will **provide practical exercises and real-world examples to enhance students' business communication skills**, ensuring they are prepared for professional interactions.

2.2. Talking on the phone: strategies and expressions for professional calls

Tips for success on the phone

- ▶ **Prepare well:** plan ahead and consider specific questions you are going to ask. Also, keep things handy, so it will be easier for you to find the information you may need.
- ▶ **Ask** the other person to speak slowly if needed.
- ▶ **Repeat** key information out loud: this way you will both know if you have understood the information correctly.
- ▶ If you don't understand, **tell them!**
- ▶ Be **polite** and **friendly**.

Important terms

- ▶ **To call:** llamar. I need to call my manager to confirm the meeting time.
- ▶ **To dial:** marcar. Please dial the number carefully to avoid mistakes.
- ▶ **Dial tone:** señal de llamada. I picked up the phone, but there was no dial tone.
- ▶ **To ring:** sonar. Her phone started to ring, but she didn't pick up.
- ▶ **To pick up:** coger el teléfono. Can you pick up the phone? I'm busy now.
- ▶ **To answer:** contestar. She answered the call after the second ring.
- ▶ **Busy signal:** ocupada. I tried to call you, but I got a busy signal.
- ▶ **To be busy:** comunicando. I couldn't reach him because his line was busy.
- ▶ **Voicemail:** buzón de voz. If I don't answer, just leave a message on my voicemail.

- ▶ **To leave a message:** dejar un mensaje. Could you please leave a message after the beep?
- ▶ **To take a message:** tomar un recado. I'm sorry. He's not in at the moment. Can I take a message?
- ▶ **To call back:** volver a llamar. He said he would call back later in the afternoon.
- ▶ **To hang up:** colgar. After the conversation, she hung up the phone.
- ▶ **Hold on:** esperar. Please, hold on while I transfer your call.
- ▶ **Speak up:** hablar más alto. Could you speak up? I can barely hear you.
- ▶ **Bad line:** mala señal. Sorry, it's a bad line. Can you repeat that?
- ▶ **To put through:** pasar la llamada. Let me put you through to the sales department.
- ▶ **Wrong number:** número equivocado. Sorry, I think you've dialed the wrong number.

Expressions to use on the phone

ANSWERING	ASKING FOR SOMEONE
• Hello, this is Juan García. • Hello, this is Juan García, calling from Bing Industries. • Hello, it's Juan García calling. • We don't say: Hello, I'm Juan García	• May I speak to George, please? • Could I speak to George, please? • I'd like to speak to... • Could you put me through to...? • Could I speak to someone in the marketing department, please?

Figure 1. Expressions: answering and asking for someone on the phone. Source: author original.

Tips for answering the phone

In the In Depth section, you can find a very interesting video on how to answer the phone correctly.

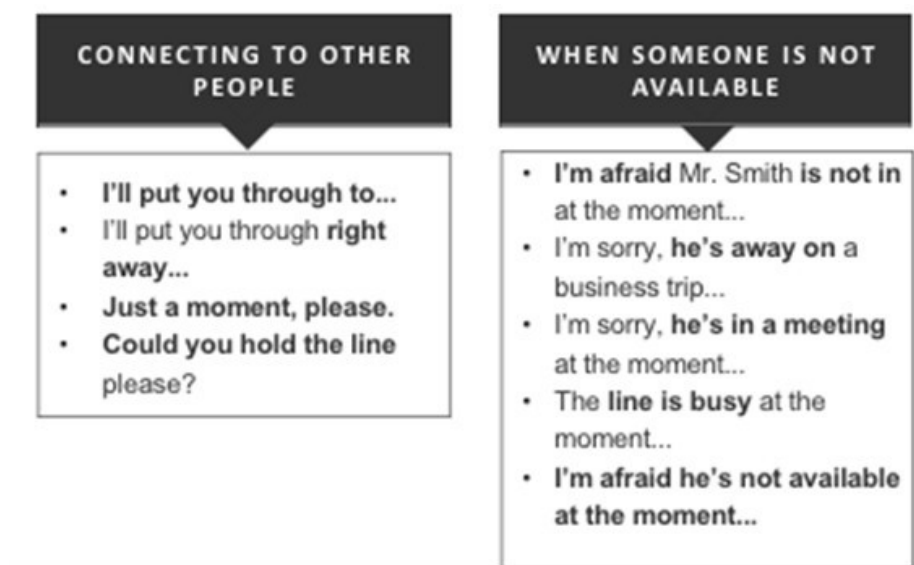


Figure 2. Expressions: connecting to other people and what to say when someone is not available on the phone. Source: author original.

Tips for leaving a message

In the In Depth section, you can find an interesting video on how to leave a message effectively.

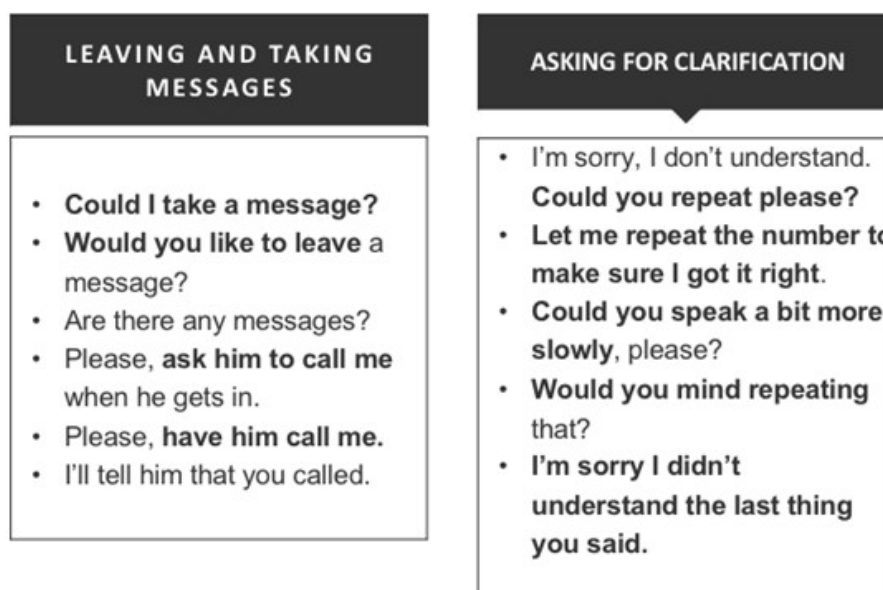


Figure 3. Expressions: leaving and taking messages; asking for clarification on the phone. Source: author original.



Figure 4. Expressions: organizing meetings on the phone. Source: author original.

Saying dates

05/05/2012

The fifth of May, two thousand and thirteen. (BR)

May fifth, two thousand and thirteen. (AM)

17/12/1987

The seventeenth of December, nineteen eighty-seven (BR)

December seventeenth, nineteen eighty-seven (AM)

Whenever you want to read dates, be careful and follow the rules according to each country:

- ▶ British English: day / month / year
- ▶ American English: month / day / year

Spelling



Example 1

Phone conversation

Receptionist: Hello, this is Sarah speaking. How can I help you?

Caller: Hello, this is John Smith calling from Global Tech Industries. May I speak to Mr. Brown, please?

Receptionist: I'm afraid Mr. Brown isn't available at the moment. Would you like to leave a message?

Caller: Yes, please. Could you ask him to call me back when he gets in?

Receptionist: Certainly. Can I take your number? Caller: Sure, it's 555-789-1234.

Receptionist: Let me repeat the number to make sure I got it right: 555-789-1234.

Caller: That's correct.

Receptionist: I'll tell him that you called. Is there anything else I can help you with?

Caller: No, that will be all. Thank you.

Receptionist: You're welcome. Have a great day!

2.3. Writing formal emails

Structure and useful expressions

GREETINGS

We have several options for starting the email:

If we don't know the name of the person we're writing to:

- Dear Sir or Madam,
- To whom it may concern,

If we know the name of the person we're writing to: DEAR + TITLE + SURNAME

- Dear Mr Bean (married or single men)
- Dr Mrs Brown (married women)
- Dear Ms Potter (for women when we don't know her marital status)
- Dear Miss Smith (single women)

After the salutation, we should always write a **comma** and continue writing in the following paragraph.

Figure 5. Formal emails (Greetings). Source: author original.

INTRODUCTION

We should introduce ourselves and explain the reason we are writing.

DONT'S: Sometimes, when starting their emails, people use the present simple instead of the present continuous. Try not to do that! Example: I send you this email.. (NO) **I'm sending this email... (YES)**

Expressions:

- I hope this email finds you well
- I hope you are well / all is well
- I am writing to you to ask ...
- I am writing to you regarding / concerning ...
- I am writing to you about ...
- Thank you for your email about ...
- Thank you for your quick reply ...
- Thank you for finding the time to write to me ...

Figure 6. Formal emails (introduction). Source: author original.

BODY	1. Get straight to the point. 2. Write short, easy and concise sentences. Make everything as clear as possible. 3. Never use contractions of verbs.
	Expressions:
	Asking for information: • Could you please send me information about ... ? • If possible, I would like to know / to have some information about ... • I would be grateful if you could give me some information / details about ... • I would appreciate if you could tell me about ...
	Files attached: • Please, find attached ... • Enclosed please find ... • The requested document is attached to this email • Please, see the attached document for more details ... • The enclosed documents show ...

Figure 7. Formal emails (body). Source: autor original.

CONCLUSION	• Thank you for your time ... • Thank you for your help ... • If you have any questions, do not hesitate to contact me... • Please, feel free to contact me if you have any questions... • I look forward to <u>hearing</u> from you...
	• Yours faithfully, (if you don't know the name of the person you are writing to) • Yours sincerely, (If you know) • Kind regards, • Respectfully,
	+ FULL NAME + SIGNATURE

Figure 8. Formal emails (conclusion and closing). Source: autor original.

Example 2

Formal email

Subject: Request for Information Regarding Internship Opportunities

Dear Mr. Smith,

I hope this email finds you well. My name is Alex, and I am currently a student in International Trade at UNIR. I am writing to inquire about potential internship opportunities.

I am particularly interested in gaining practical experience in the logistics department as it aligns with my academic background and career aspirations. I would appreciate any information you could provide regarding available positions, application procedures, and required qualifications.

Please let me know if there is a convenient time for us to discuss this further. I am happy to provide any additional information you may need.

Thank you in advance for your time and consideration. I look forward to your response.

Best regards,

Alex

Do's and don'ts

When writing a formal email, make sure you...

- ▶ Do not use contractions
- ▶ Write your full name underneath the signature.
- ▶ Use indirect questions ("Could you please tell me ...?") instead of direct questions.

- ▶ Write direct and concise emails, it is important that your email is clear to the person who is going to read it.
- ▶ Remember to always reread your email before sending it to check for any mistakes.

Vocabulary

Parts and functions of an email:

- ▶ **Inbox:** bandeja de entrada – My inbox is full of unread messages.
- ▶ **Outbox:** bandeja de salida – The email is still in my outbox because of a slow connection.
- ▶ **Drafts:** borradores – I saved the email in drafts to review it later.
- ▶ **Trash / Bin:** papelera – I accidentally deleted an important email and now it's in the trash.
- ▶ **Spam / Junk mail:** correo no deseado – Your email might have gone to my spam folder.

Email actions:

- ▶ **To reply:** responder – I need to reply to my client's email as soon as possible.
- ▶ **To forward:** reenviar – Can you forward me the email with the meeting details?
- ▶ **To attach:** adjuntar – Please attach the contract to the email before sending it.
- ▶ **To delete:** borrar – I accidentally deleted the email, can you resend it?
- ▶ **To archive:** archivar – I always archive old emails instead of deleting them.
- ▶ **To mark as unread:** marcar como leído – I marked the email as unread so I can check it later.

- ▶ **To flag / To star**: marcar como importante (con una bandera o Estrella) – I flagged the email because it contains important information.

Email elements:

- ▶ **Subject line**: asunto – The subject line should be clear and concise.
- ▶ **Header**: encabezado – The email header contains the sender's details.
- ▶ **Body**: cuerpo del correo – The body of the email should be well-structured and polite.
- ▶ **Signature**: firma – I added my company's logo to my email signature.
- ▶ **Attachment**: archive adjunto – The attachment is too large to send via email.
- ▶ **Read receipt**: confirmación de lectura – I enabled a read receipt to confirm when the recipient opens my email.

2.4. Grammar check

Past simple

Past simple is used to **describe actions that happened at a specific time in the past**. These actions are **completed** and do not have a direct connection to the present.

There are two types of verbs: regular and irregular.

REGULAR VERBS		
We only need to add -ed in the affirmative form		
AFFIRMATIVE	NEGATIVE	INTERROGATIVE
I worked You worked He/She/It worked We worked You worked They worked	I didn't work You didn't work He/She/It didn't work We didn't work You didn't work They didn't work	Did I work? Did you work? Did he/she/it work? Did we work? Did you work? Did they work?

Figure 9. Past simple (regular verbs). Source: author original.

IRREGULAR VERBS		
2 ND column of the irregular verbs list for the affirmative form		
AFFIRMATIVE	NEGATIVE	INTERROGATIVE
I went You went He/She/It went We went You went They went	I didn't go You didn't go He/She/It didn't go We didn't go You didn't go They didn't go	Did I go? Did you go? Did he/she/it go? Did we go? Did you go? Did they go?

Figure 10. Past simple (irregular verbs). Source: author original.

KEYWORDS	• Yesterday • Last week/month/year • Two days ago • In 2010 • When I was a child
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Figure 11. Past simple (keywords). Source: author original.

Example 3

Past simple

- I visited my parents last weekend.
- She studied French at university.
- They went to Italy last holidays.
- I didn't watch a great movie last night.
- He didn't buy a car last month.
- Did you go to the party yesterday?
- Did they meet in 2019?

Past continuous

Past continuous is used to **describe actions that were happening at a specific moment in the past**. It often sets the scene in a story or describes background actions. We use past continuous to talk about:

- ▶ An action in progress at a specific moment in the past:
 - At 8 p.m. yesterday, I was studying.

- ▶ Two actions happening at the same time:
 - While she was cooking, he was setting the table.
- ▶ An action interrupted by another action (past simple + past continuous):
 - I **was walking** in the park **when it started** to rain.

To form it, we need the **VERB TO BE IN PAST + THE MAIN VERB IN GERUND**. In this case, **we don't mind if the verb is regular or irregular**.

PAST CONTINUOUS		
VERB TO BE IN PAST + MAIN VERB IN GERUND		
AFFIRMATIVE	NEGATIVE	INTERROGATIVE
I was going You were going He/She/It was going We were going You were going They were going	I wasn't going You weren't going He/She/It wasn't going We weren't going You weren't going They weren't going	Was I going ? Were you going ? Was he/she/it going ? Were we going ? Were you going ? Were they going ?

Figure 12. Past continuous. Source: author original.

KEYWORDS	• While • When • At that moment • All morning/evening/day
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Figure 13. Past continuous (keywords). Source: author original.

Example 4

Past continuous

- I was watching TV when the phone rang.
- She was studying for the exam all afternoon.
- They weren't playing football at 5 pm yesterday.
- Was he reading a book while she was cooking?
- We were driving to the airport when it started to rain.

Modal verbs

Modal verbs are auxiliary verbs that express necessity, ability, permission, probability, and other related meanings. They are followed by the base form of the main verb (without "to").

Modal verb	Function	Example
CAN	Ability, permission	She can swim very well. / Can I go out?
COULD	Past ability, polite request	I could run fast when I was younger. / Could you help me?
MAY	Permission, possibility	May I leave early? / It may rain later.
MIGHT	Possibility (less certain than "may")	She might come to the party.
MUST	Strong necessity or obligation	You must wear a seatbelt.
SHOULD	Advice, recommendation	You should study more.
SHALL	Formal future intention or suggestion	Shall we begin?

Figure 14. Modal verbs. Source: author original.

Key characteristics of Modal Verbs:

- ▶ They do not take **"-s" in the third person singular** (*He **can** swim*, not *He **cans** swim*).
- ▶ They are **followed by the base form of the main verb** (*She **must go***, not *She **must to go***).
- ▶ They **do not need auxiliary verbs to form negatives** or questions (***Can** she swim?* / *She **cannot** (**can't**) swim.*).

2.5. References

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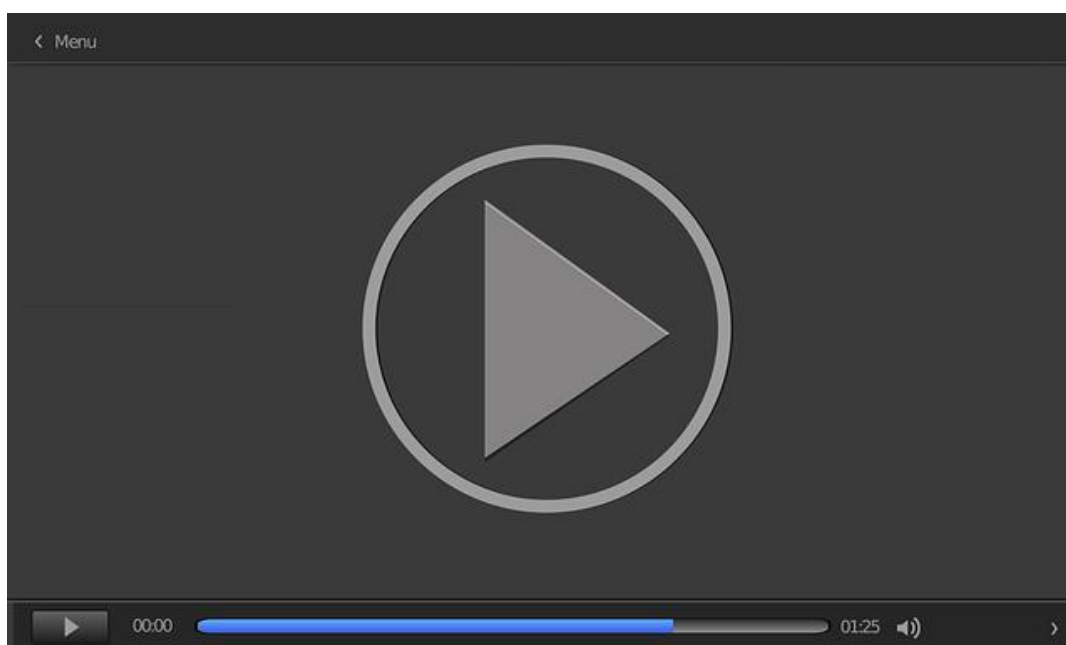
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Tips for answering the phone

Kyle Millar Business. (2014, 26 marzo). *Business English Top Tips Video #5* [Vídeo]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eZThlh07QCg>

This video shows an example on how not to answer the phone and how to do it correctly following useful tips.



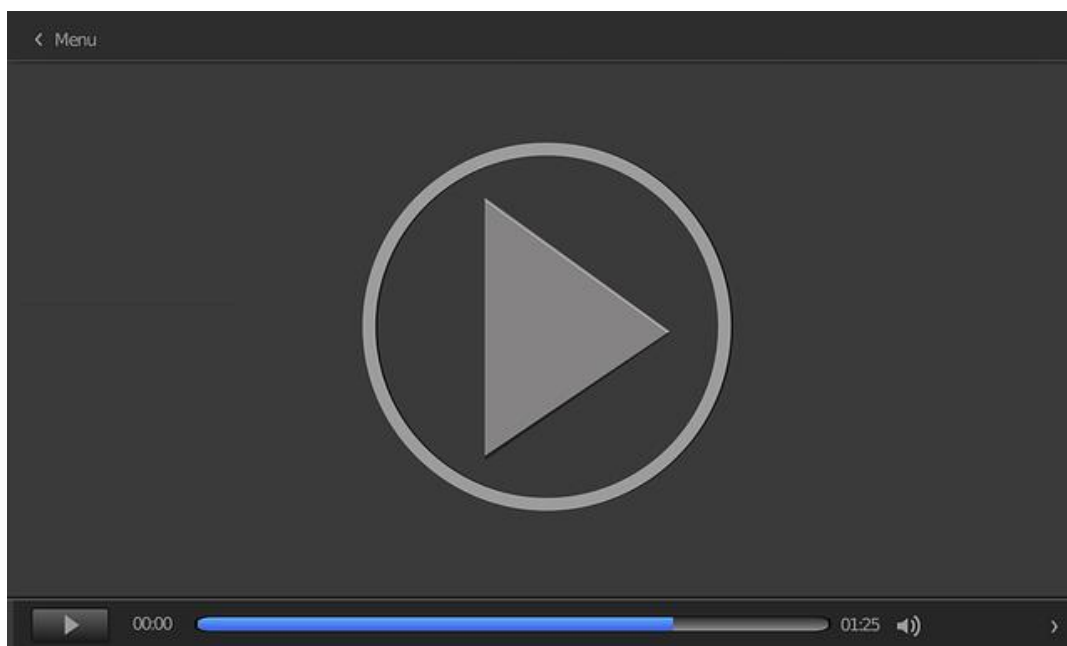
Accede al vídeo:

<https://www.youtube.com/embed/eZThlh07QCg>

Tips for leaving a message

Kyle Millar Business. (2014a, marzo 23). *Business English Top Tips Video#6* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xxTfGSacco4>

This video shows an example on how not to leave a message and how to do it effectively following useful tips. Always include your full name, the reason for calling and a telephone number so they can call you back. You can even repeat the phone number to make sure they got it correctly.



Accede al vídeo:

<https://www.youtube.com/embed/xxTfGSacco4>

Training 1. On the phone

- **Complete** the dialogue with the **vocabulary** and **expressions** from the box.

May I speak to - I'm afraid – available – put you through – hold the line – leave a message – call me back - repeat

Receptionist: Good morning, Global Solutions Ltd. How can I help you?

Caller: Hello, this is Daniel Carter. _____ (1) Mr. Johnson, please?

Receptionist: Certainly. I'll _____ (2) to his office. One moment, please.

(After a short pause)

Receptionist: _____ (3) Mr. Johnson isn't _____ (4) at the moment. Would you like to _____ (5)?

Caller: Yes, please. Could you tell him that I called and ask him to _____ (6) as soon as possible?

Receptionist: Of course. May I know what the call is for?

Caller: It's regarding the new contract proposal.

Receptionist: Understood. Let me confirm your details. Your name is Daniel Carter, correct?

Caller: Yes, that's right.

Receptionist: And could you _____ (7) your phone number, please?

Caller: Sure, it's 555-897-2345.

Receptionist: Let me read that back to you: 555-897-2345.

Caller: That's correct.

Receptionist: Perfect. I'll make sure Mr. Johnson gets your message.

Caller: Thank you for your help.

Receptionist: You're welcome! Have a great day.

Caller: You too. Goodbye.

Solution 1:

Receptionist: Good morning, Global Solutions Ltd. How can I help you?

Caller: Hello, this is Daniel Carter. **May I speak to** (1) Mr. Johnson, please?

Receptionist: Certainly. I'll **put you through** (2) to his office. One moment, please.

(After a short pause)

Receptionist: I'm afraid (3) Mr. Johnson isn't **available** (4) at the moment. Would you like to **leave a message** (5)?

Caller: Yes, please. Could you tell him that I called and ask him to **call me back** (6) as soon as possible?

Receptionist: Of course. May I know what the call is for?

Caller: It's regarding the new contract proposal.

Receptionist: Understood. Let me confirm your details. Your name is Daniel Carter, correct?

Caller: Yes, that's right.

Receptionist: And could you **repeat** (7) your phone number, please?

Caller: Sure, it's 555-897-2345.

Receptionist: Let me read that back to you: 555-897-2345.

Caller: That's correct.

Receptionist: Perfect. I'll make sure Mr. Johnson gets your message.

Caller: Thank you for your help.

Receptionist: You're welcome! Have a great day.

Caller: You too. Goodbye.

Training 2. Writing formal emails

- ▶ Write a short formal email to someone you work with. You choose the topic and the person you're writing to.
- ▶ Remember that, in your email, you should follow the structure and use the expressions covered in the unit.

Solution 2

There is no single solution for this activity, so here is an example of a possible answer:

Subject: Request for Meeting

Dear Mr. Brown,

I hope you are doing well. I am writing to discuss the upcoming project deadline and would like to arrange a meeting to go over the details.

It would be great to set up a time that works for both of us. Would you be available on Monday at 10 am? If not, please let me know your availability.

Looking forward to your response.

Best regards,

Alex Smith.

Training 3. Past simple

- ▶ Complete the sentences with the correct form of the verbs in brackets.
- ▶ 1. I _____ (wake up) early and _____ (have) breakfast at 7 am.
- ▶ 2. She _____ (not go) to school yesterday because she was sick.
- ▶ 3. They _____ (visit) their grandparents last weekend.
- ▶ 4. _____ you _____ (watch) a great movie last night?
- ▶ 5. My father _____ (buy) a new laptop last month.
- ▶ 6. He _____ (finish) his work and then _____ (go) home.
- ▶ 7. She _____ (lose) her phone on her way to school.
- ▶ 8. The teacher _____ (explain) the lesson very clearly.
- ▶ 9. _____ you _____ (get) married in 1995?
- ▶ 10. She _____ (find) a wallet on the street and _____ (take) it to the police.

Solution 3

- ▶ 1. I _____ (wake up) early and _____ (have) breakfast at 7 am.
- ▶ 2. She _____ (not go) to school yesterday because she was sick.
- ▶ 3. They _____ (visit) their grandparents last weekend.
- ▶ 4. _____ you _____ (watch) a great movie last night?
- ▶ 5. My father _____ (buy) a new laptop last month.
- ▶ 6. He _____ (finish) his work and then _____ (go) home.

- ▶ 7. She _____ (lose) her phone on her way to school.
- ▶ 8. The teacher _____ (explain) the lesson very clearly.
- ▶ 9. _____ you _____ (get) married in 1995?
- ▶ 10. She _____ (find) a wallet on the street and _____ (take) it to the police.

Training 4. Past continuous

► Complete the sentences with the correct form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1. At 6 pm yesterday, I _____ (cook) dinner.
- 2. She _____ (not sleep) when the alarm rang.
- 3. We _____ (walk) in the park when it started to rain.
- 4. They _____ (play) football while their parents _____ (watch) TV.
- 5. I _____ (pay) attention in class.
- 6. _____ you _____ (write) an email when I called you?
- 7. While she _____ (drive), she saw an accident.
- 8. _____ he _____ (listen) to music when I arrived?
- 9. The children _____ (swim) in the pool when it started to rain.
- 10. What _____ you _____ (do) yesterday at 8 am?

Solution 4

- 1. At 6 pm yesterday, I was cooking (cook) dinner.
- 2. She wasn't sleeping (not sleep) when the alarm rang.
- 3. We were walking (walk) in the park when it started to rain.
- 4. They were playing (play) football while their parents were watching (watch) TV.
- 5. I was paying (pay) attention in class.
- 6. Were you writing (write) an email when I called you?

- ▶ 7. While she was driving (drive), she saw an accident.
- ▶ 8. Was he listening (listen) to music when I arrived?
- ▶ 9. The children were swimming (swim) in the pool when it started to rain.
- ▶ 10. What were you **doing** (do) yesterday at 8 am?

Training 5. Past simple vs Past continuous

- ▶ Complete the sentences using Past simple or Past continuous.
- ▶ 1. He _____ (watch) TV when he suddenly _____ (hear) a noise.
- ▶ 2. The children _____ (play) in the garden when it _____ (start) to rain.
- ▶ 3. While we _____ (walk) in the forest, we _____ (find) a lost dog.
- ▶ 4. My mom _____ (come) home, while I _____ (do) my homework.
- ▶ 5. While he _____ (wait) for the bus, I _____ (walk) home by foot.

Solution 5

- ▶ 1. He was watching (watch) TV when he suddenly heard (hear) a noise.
- ▶ 2. The children were playing (play) in the garden when it started (start) to rain.
- ▶ 3. While we were walking (walk) in the forest, we found (find) a lost dog.
- ▶ 4. My mom came (come) home, while I was doing (do) my homework.
- ▶ 5. While he **was waiting** (wait) for the bus, I **was walking** (walk) home by foot.

Training 6. Modal verbs

Complete the sentences with the correct modal verb from the ones in the box.

Shouldn't – shall – must – might – can – should – mustn't

- ▶ 1. You _____ wear a seatbelt while driving. It's the law.
- ▶ 2. You _____ leave your bags unattended in the airport. It's not safe.
- ▶ 3. You _____ arrive late to the meeting. The boss won't be happy.
- ▶ 4. _____ we start the meeting?
- ▶ 5. I _____ speak three languages fluently.
- ▶ 6. They _____ be at home now, but I'm not sure.
- ▶ 7. You _____ wear an umbrella. It's going to rain.

Solution 6

- ▶ 1. You **must** wear a seatbelt while driving. It's the law. (obligation)
- ▶ 2. You **shouldn't** leave your bags unattended in the airport. It's not safe. (advice)
- ▶ 3. You **mustn't** arrive late to the meeting. The boss won't be happy. (prohibition)
- ▶ 4. **Shall** we start the meeting? (formal suggestion)
- ▶ 5. I **can** speak three languages fluently. (ability)
- ▶ 6. They **might** be at home now, but I'm not sure. (**possibility**)
- ▶ 7. You **should** wear an umbrella. It's going to rain. (**advice**)